DIRTY WORDS

SEXUALITY

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2018/ 2019

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PROTEIN AGENCY

DIRTY WORDS

REDEFINING THE MEANING OF
MEANINGLESS WORDS

DIRTY WORDS

~~EXCLUSIVITY~~
AUTHENTICITY
COMMUNITY
SUSTAINABILITY
LOYALTY
RELEVANCE
CULTURE
CONTENT
INFLUENCE
INNOVATION

EXCLUSIVITY

DEFINING DIRTY- WORDS

WE WANT TO LOOK AT KEY WORDS THAT STAND OUT IN THE INDUSTRY AROUND PRODUCTS, BRANDS AND MEDIA AND TO UNPACK THE DISCONNECT IN MEANING BETWEEN INDIVIDUALS AND COMPANIES. WE THINK OF THESE AS 'DIRTY WORDS', WHOSE ORIGINAL MEANING HAS BEEN MODIFIED BY CULTURAL SHIFTS.

AS THE CONCEPT BEHIND A 'DIRTY WORD' PROLIFERATES, IT GATHERS CULTURAL BAGGAGE AND BECOMES INCREASINGLY NARROW IN DEFINITION. WE WANT TO ZOOM OUT AND RE-FOCUS ON THE WORDS WE'RE USING. THE INTENTION IS NOT TO REACH AN OBJECTIVE DEFINITION OF EACH 'DIRTY WORD', BUT TO EXPLORE CONCEPTS AND (HOPEFULLY) BUILD A FOUNDATION FOR DISCUSSION.

WHAT THIS IS: ? ¿ ?

ISSUE 1 LOOKS AT 'EXCLUSIVITY', A CONCEPT THAT HAS PERMEATED EVERY ASPECT OF CONTEMPORARY CONSUMER CULTURE AND HAS BECOME SYNONYMOUS WITH HYPE, ENGAGEMENT AND BUSINESS MODELS.

WE WANT TO UNDERSTAND: IF EVERYTHING TODAY IS 'EXCLUSIVE', WHAT MAKES A PRODUCT SPECIAL?

PROTEIN AGENCY

PEAK EXCLU-SIVITY



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IDEAS AROUND EXCLUSIVITY ARE SHIFTING AS RELATIONSHIPS WITH BRANDS ARE EVOLVING.

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ROLE OF BRANDS

HOW CONSUMERS RELATE AND ENGAGE WITH BRANDS, A RECENT HISTORY

PAST

BRAND AS STATUS

: TRADITIONAL MODEL

Previously brands conferred literal status and their products were used as a medium to elevate identity.

Value was determined by price and brands became status symbols for success.

PREVIOUS

BRAND AS LIFESTYLE

: CRAFT MOVEMENT

The advent of social media created a space for individuals to showcase their curated, polished and branded selves.

Universal brands stopped resonating as they didn't offer individuality. Smaller 'craft' brands were embraced as they enhance a portrayal of discernment.

PRESENT

PRODUCT OVER BRAND

: RETURN OF BIG BRANDS (VALUE)

Consumers reached a saturation point of personal representation through artisanal brands.

Diverging from prevailing ideals of 'authenticity' and lifestyle curation, people are judging products, brands and services in a rational and value-driven way.

PROGRESSIVE

BRAND CONSTRUCT

: NEW INTENTIONS (VALUES)

Consumers are beginning to buy into a brand's subjective vision for the future, not just their contemporary cultural relevance.

A post-consumer mindset means people will increasingly choose brands based on values and constructs, not just products.

PERFORMATIVE → PERSONAL

BRAND/CONSUMER DYNAMIC

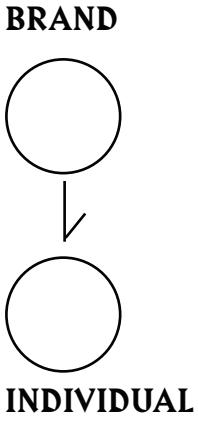
HOW CONSUMERS AND BRANDS CONNECT, INTERACT AND COMMUNICATE

PAST

BRAND AS STATUS

: CONFINED CONSUMPTION

A top-down relationship: People buying into the aspirational lifestyles constructed by brands.

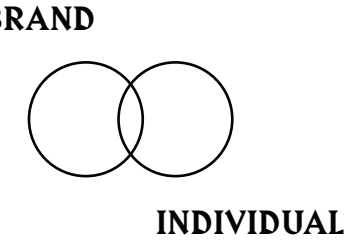


PREVIOUS

BRAND AS LIFESTYLE

: CULTURAL CONSUMPTION

An assimilated relationship: Brands and individuals use each other to define and represent themselves e.g. content co-creation.

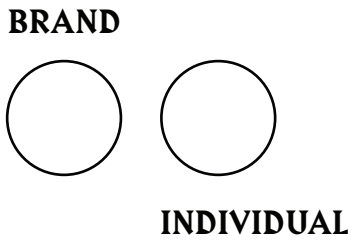


PRESENT

PRODUCT OVER BRAND

: CRITICAL CONSUMPTION

A transactional relationship: Brands have less emotional influence on the individual who now rationally assesses the true value of an item.

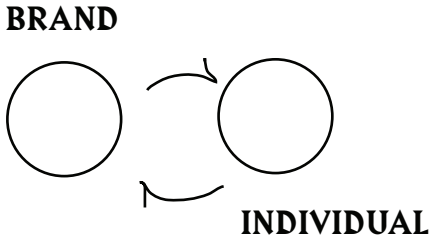


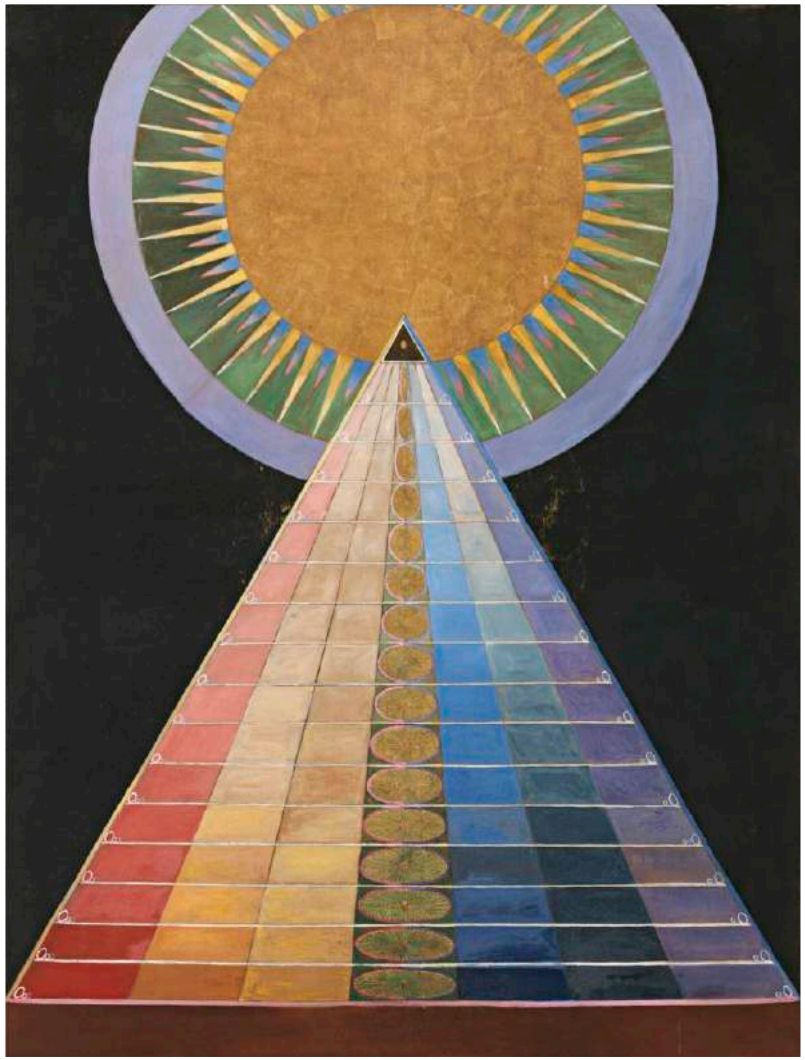
PROGRESSIVE

BRAND CONSTRUCT

: CONVERSATIONAL CONSUMPTION

A symbiotic relationship: The dynamic between brands and consumers becomes one based on conversation and informed development.





HIMLA AF KLINT

NEW AGE CONSUMPTION 08

Individuals are moving away from blind allegiances to product lines and traditional cycles of buying to looking critically at a brands' (utopic) visions of the future in search of something more sustainable and personal.

Personal in terms of products or brands which speak beyond aesthetic or utility towards individuals' interests or ideologies.

Sustainable in terms of whole-system longevity; things that are made to culturally and physically last.

DRIVERS OF CHANGE

INCLUSION

When the current political climate is one that singles out groups for their beliefs and backgrounds, excluding others feels neither positive nor progressive. Individuals are fighting for the inclusion of those who are marginalized, creating a middle ground for discussions of difference and shifting from a mindset of passive tolerance of those who have opposing opinions to a mindset of active acceptance.

STABILITY

In transitionary times, individuals are seeking stability and consistency they can relate to and invest in. Ideas of sustainability are shifting from conversations solely around the manufacture of tangible products to seeking longevity in multiple arenas, including philosophical and social ideologies (e.g. closed loop systems, social movements, communities, emotional states, ideas of value).

SUBJECTIVITY

With infinite social media opinions and the news pregnant with rhetoric, people are searching for perspectives that feel genuine and relatable. Conflicting versions of ostensibly objective "truths" create confusion, leaving people unable to make informed and considered decisions. A spectrum of personal narratives and experiences feel more truthful than binaries of right and wrong.

FATIGUE

Trend cycles and drop culture are emotionally and financially unsustainable for consumers. High frequency and turnover leaves no space for surprise, suspense or anticipation. 'Specialness' around exclusive products is being diluted, emotion is being dulled and individuals are searching for something more fulfilling.

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EXCLUSIVITY IS CHANGING BECAUSE SOCIETY IS CHANGING.

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COMMUNITY DEFINITIONS

NEW YORK

Everything is 'exclusive' nowadays, and that's the problem.
— Ben, 25

Exclusivity is when something, whether it be people, a company or congregation feel that only few can have the best, while the rest have lesser versions.
— Carma, 21

Exclusivity used to be seductive when the idea of 'membership' and class signaling were seen as natural and buying into something elite was romanticized.
— Betty, 26

Exclusivity is an unnecessary separation.
— Augustus, 16

Exclusivity doesn't exist anymore because everything is so accessible.
— Olu, 28

Exclusivity is manmade scarcity, it's an intentional rareness that's used to imbue added value in an object.
— Amardeep, 27

LONDON

Exclusivity is just economics - scarcity increases demand.
— Robin, 33

Exclusivity will always mean excluding a group of people which feels very outdated and consumeristic to me, making us want what we don't or sometimes can't have.
— Shadeh, 24

Exclusivity just means that the demand exceeds the supply, but also, marketing makes a big difference.
— Lewis, 22

Exclusivity isn't real, it's a construct created to make you feel special.
— Jaffa, 18

Exclusivity is limited access or reach to something that is considered special in a certain way or form.
— Aliyah, 18

AMSTERDAM

Exclusivity obviously varies per culture or product and is something that comes into existence because it's culturally understood through some type of hierarchy.
— Ilias, 22

At its core I think exclusivity is belonging to a specific and limited group of people, power, status, but I think exclusivity is not only about the 'belonging to or owning of' but rather the knowledge around it.
— Debbie, 21

Exclusivity has changed. There has been a shift from exclusivity in terms of product availability and calculated scarcity to a secondary market purchasing behavior that aims to display a type of exclusivity that is linked not to what is bought but how it is bought.
— Laurens, 26

Companies are playing with the idea of exclusivity more and more through a higher frequency of drops and constant collaborations. It feels like it's just a psychological/capitalistic tool.
— Terrell, 30

In times of over consumption, we feel the urge to differentiate and individualize, exclusivity will be even more present in future times as a way to do that.
— Dominik, 24

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**TODAY,
EXCLUSIVITY IS
TRANSACTIONAL -
BRANDS CREATE IT,
INDIVIDUALS
CONSUME IT.**

FROM PERFORMANCE TO PERSONAL

The understanding of exclusivity is moving from a desire for something performative and dramatic (scarcity, drop culture, limited editions) to a desire for something personal and specific (archiving, customization, new ideologies). *The dynamic has shifted from a brand determining what is exclusive to an individual determining what is exclusive to them.*

MODES OF PRODUCT EXCLUSIVITY

PROPER — POPULAR — PROGRESSIVE — N!E!W!

EXCLUSIVE IN PRICE



EXCLUSIVE IN QUANTITY



EXCLUSIVE IN JOURNEY



EXCLUSIVE IN CREATION



EXCLUSIVE IN IDEA



LUXURY

Exclusionary with a red velvet rope. Indulging in high price tags and symbols of status portrays an established and aspirational lifestyle.

EDITION

Buying into the cycle of drops, celebrating brand culture and chasing limited editions and collaborations. These items are symbols of contemporary relevance.

Street culture becomes pop culture. Brands use scarcity and hype to challenge traditional supply and demand models.

ARCHIVED

Redirecting time and energy spent chasing new releases to discovering out of production pieces deemed to be culturally pivotal. Turning to the archives shows a deeper understanding of brands and items.

Hype and culture become commodified and people begin to question the depth, purpose, and meaning of any given release..

CUSTOM

Stepping outside of a uniformed and formulaic approach to products and brands, they are choosing items developed with specific consideration to their wider lifestyles.

Realization that rareness is not the true meaning of individuality. Seeking opportunities for personalization that reflect their wider lifestyle.

IDEOLOGY

Challenging the idea of individuality through exclusive product and brands, they are opting for brands with a strong concept that reflect their personal worldview and values.

Attitude that one doesn't need a unique product to be a unique person; that individuality is about a mentality, not a product or brand.

BRAND-DETERMINED EXLUSIVITY: PERFORMATIVE — INDIVIDUAL-DETERMINED EXCLUSIVITY: PERSONAL

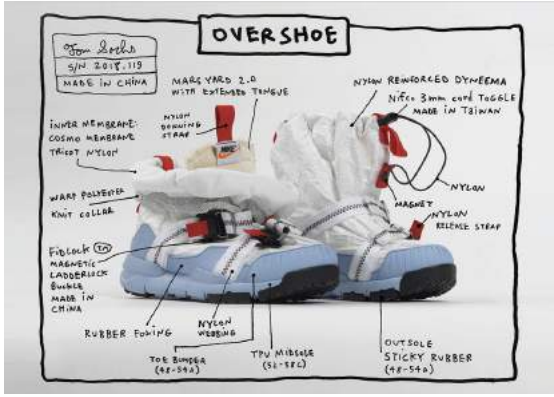
DIRTY WORDS

EXCLUSIVITY

PROTEIN AGENCY

EDITION

EXCLUSIVE IN QUANTITY



1

TOM SACHS X NIKE

The Overshoe was 3rd in a series of collaborations between artist Tom Sachs and Nike. Each release has additional exclusive content created around the product. e.g. print, films, or IRL obstacle courses that are invite only where the completion of the obstacle course is a key step in purchasing the sneaker.



2

SOCIAL STUDIES X THE NORTH FACE

Social Studies is a 3-day retail pop-up at Milk Studios by Baque Creative. They collaborated with The North Face to create a 1-of-1, hand silk-screened bespoke Nuptse jacket available for auction exclusively on Grailed. As of Nov 21, the bid was at $8000.



3

TRAVIS SCOTT ASTROWORLD

Travis Scott did a 12-hour-only limited release sale on November 27th for his Astroworld merch, for those that didn't get it at the event. The sweatshirts are now reselling for $200-$400 on Grailed and StockX.

PROTEIN AGENCY

ARCHIVE

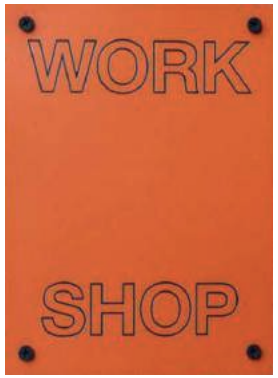
EXCLUSIVE IN JOURNEY



1

SUPREME COPIES

Supreme Copies is an Instagram account turned coffee table book that chronicles Supreme and their breadth of graphic references and serves as a design and fashion archive.



2

WORKSHOP

Workshop is a progressive retail concept and platform by Our Legacy with doors in Stockholm, London and Tokyo. Our Legacy opens their past seasons, archives and previously unknown references to customers at the Workshop as a way to communicate the brand on a more holistic level.



3

ENDYMA

Endyma, is an interdisciplinary project by Michael Kardamakis and is one of the largest Helmut Lang collections to date. Part garment archive for sale, part research project, his site and showroom (by appointment only) is a haven for fashion historians, and has amassed the biggest collection of Helmut Lang (1986-2005) in the world.

CUSTOM

EXCLUSIVE IN CREATION



1

GENUINE LIQUORETTE

Founded in NYC and recently opened in London, Genuine Liquorette is a cocktail bar that offers drink co-creation and customization. Whether through their pre-purchase and self-mix packs that include miniature spirits and soft mixers or through cocktail customization in consultation with a bartender, they're making the co-creation and individualization of drinks central to the experience.



2

THE NUE CO

The Nue Co. is an NYC-based custom supplement company. After collecting information on current health and desired outcomes, the company is able to customize formulae then respond to and recalibrate for the customer's changing needs as the subscription progresses.



3

PROSE

Prose is an NYC-based, algorithm-driven hair care brand. The custom solution takes into account hair and scalp needs and goals as well as grooming habits and environmental exposure (pollution, UV, humidity, etc.) to create a bespoke product not only for an individual's body, but for their lifestyle as well.

PROTEIN AGENCY

IDEOLOGY

EXCLUSIVE IN IDEA



1

SEXYLAND

SEXYLAND is an Amsterdam-based contemporary club concept. Based on a membership program, every single night is run by a member, no two nights are alike and ownership and the power of curation are distributed among the community.



2

FOR DAYS

For Days is a Los Angeles-based sustainable t-shirt subscription service and closed-loop brand. The concept is that you never really "own" the shirts; you wear them out and then return them (to be bleached, re-dyed and rewoven) in exchange for new ones.

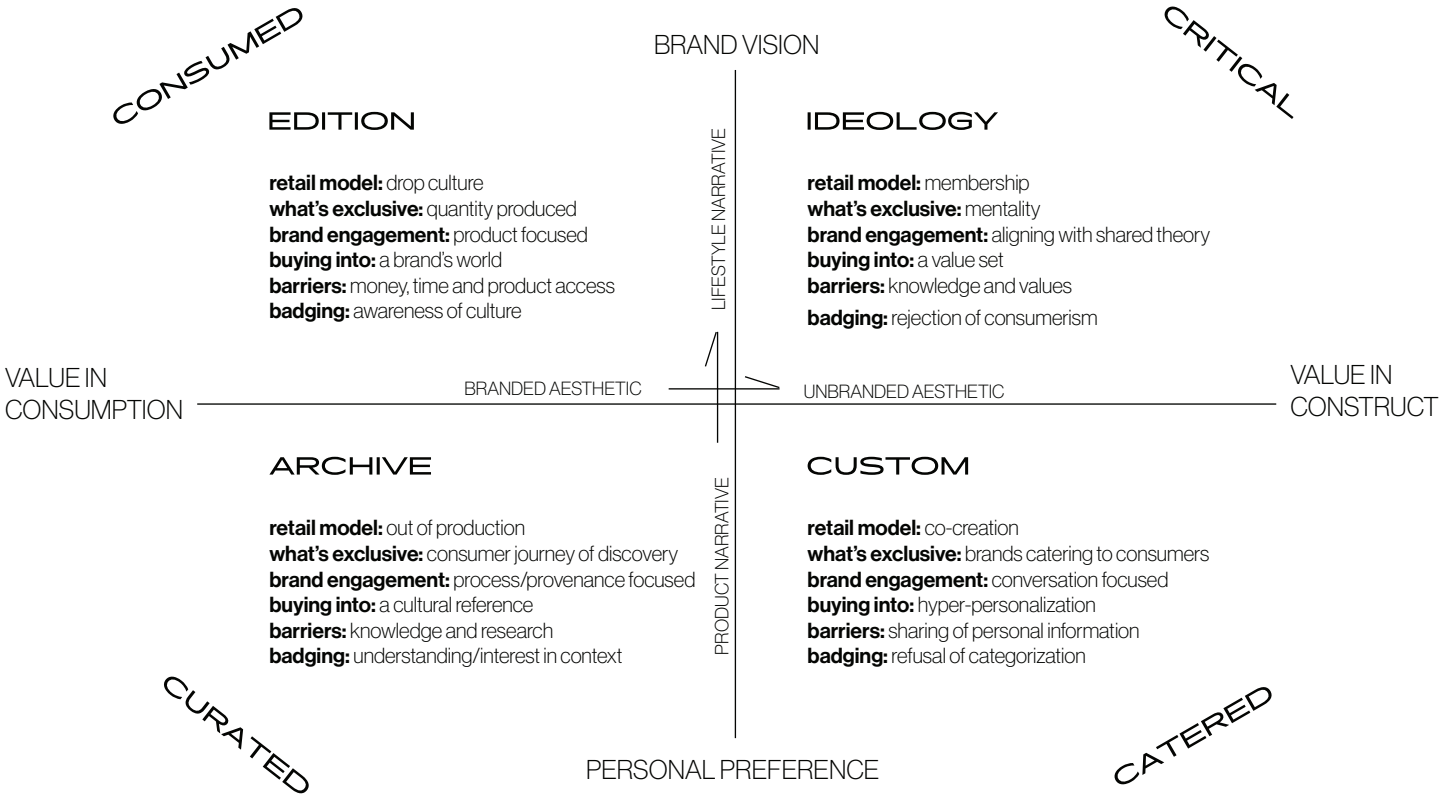


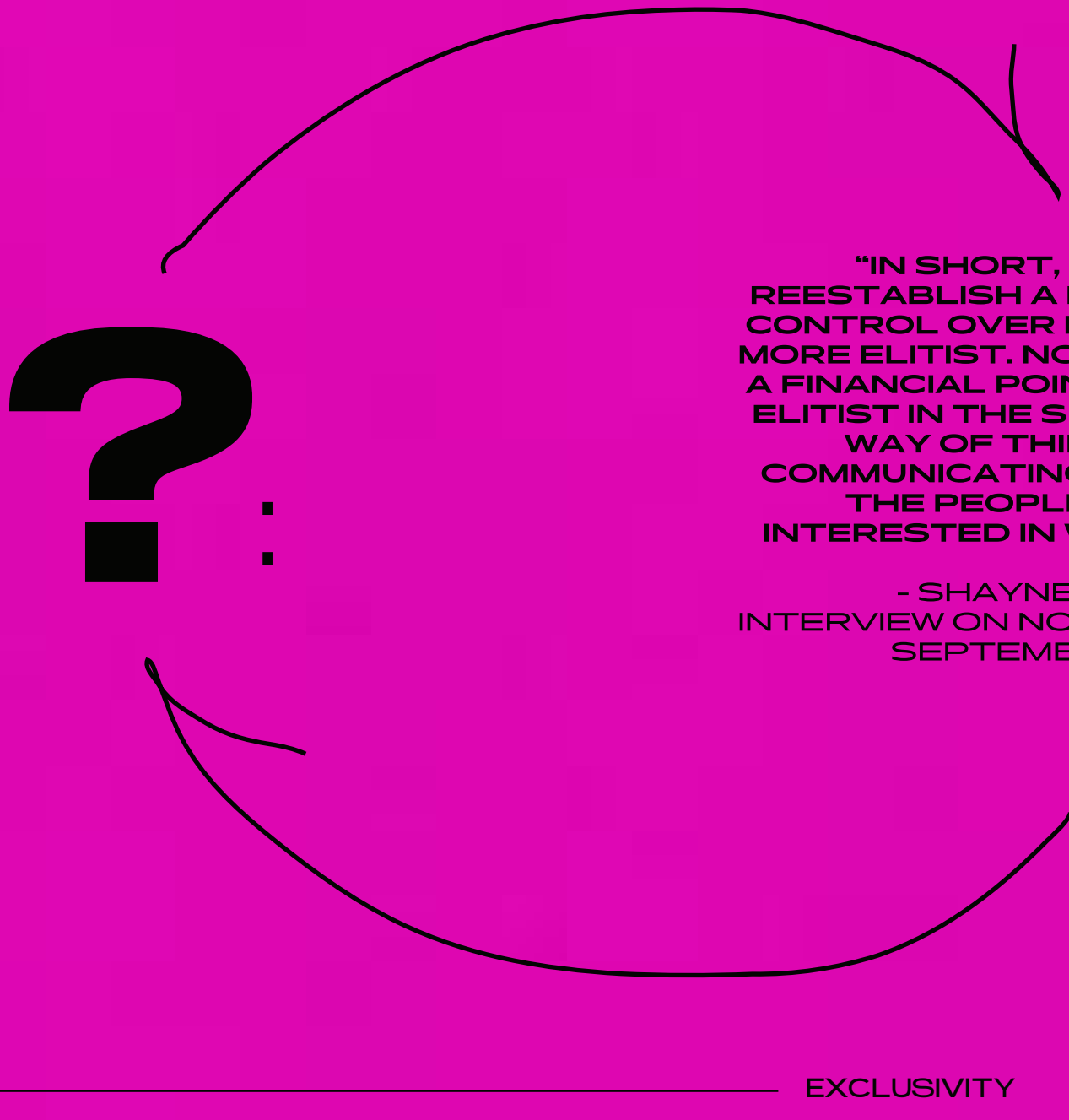
3

LOT2046

LOT2046 is a Los Angeles and Shenzhen-based subscription service that periodically distributes clothing, footwear, self-care products, accessories, and media content. Promising to change your life, the brand is based on a near future ideology that subscribers literally buy into, creating an anonymous membership community.

MODES OF PRODUCT EXCLUSIVITY





“IN SHORT, I WANT TO REESTABLISH A MORE INTIMATE CONTROL OVER MY OWN BRAND, MORE ELITIST. NOT ELITIST FROM A FINANCIAL POINT OF VIEW, BUT ELITIST IN THE SENSE OF A NEW WAY OF THINKING AND COMMUNICATING YOUR ART TO THE PEOPLE WHO ARE INTERESTED IN WHAT YOU DO.”

- SHAYNE OLIVER
INTERVIEW ON NOWFASHION.COM,
SEPTEMBER 2018

SO WHAT ?

TAKEAWAYS FOR YOU

NEW REASONS

Exclusivity in product remains about expressing individuality, but it is moving from something that outwardly exhibits difference (status symbols) to something that's internalized and more worldview driven (ideology). The new ways of determining a product's value are shifting from the physical to the conceptual.

NEW FORMS

Exclusivity has shifted in form from markers of contemporary cultural relevance to more subtle symbols of knowledge and values. Visually, products are moving from the overtly branded to the unbranded, from the formulaic to the fully customizable and from the publicly identifiable to identifiable only by communities with shared values. Design has shifted from the performative to the personal.

NEW BARRIERS TO ENTRY

Access to exclusive products is changing from being dictated by brand constructed barriers (quantity and price) to personally constructed barriers (interest and input). Progressive products and brands are inclusive only for those genuinely interested in the vision or idea.

NEW RULES OF ENGAGEMENT

Exclusivity isn't about exclusion, but conditional inclusion. Relationships between brands and consumers are moving away from a top-down, hierarchical system to a symbiotic, responsive and respectful dialogue that focuses on cooperative and mutually beneficial development.

EXCLUSIVITY HAS NEW MODES & MEANING

LIMITED PRODUCTS	FOCUSED WORLDS
CAPITAL LED EXCLUSION	KNOWLEDGE LED INCLUSION
A FOCUS ON NOWNESS	A FOCUS ON NARRATIVE
PUBLIC DISPLAY	PERSONAL CONNECTION
CONSUMERISM	CONVERSATIONS
ELITISM	EMPATHY
MARKETING	MEANING
PHYSICAL	CONCEPTUAL

IN CONVERSATION WITH:

ENDYMA
PROSE
SEXYLAND
LOT2046

ENDYMA

DATE: November 26, 2018

TIME: 10:30am

We spoke with Michael Kardamakis, the founder of ENDYMA, a fashion archive project based in Athens with the biggest Helmut Lang collection in the world.

Jamie McCracken: Hey, how is the exhibition in London?

Michael Kardama: It's good, it's been going great. It's the fourth day now.

JM: Amazing, and it's in OTHER/shop?

MK: Yeah, correct.

JM: Such a good store, by far my favorite shop in London.

MK: Yeah, they're great guys too. It's nice working with them for this.

JM: Yeah, I'll bet, super relaxed. For this publication, we love your project so we wanted to hear a little bit more so I guess, how would you explain ENDYMA in a succinct sentence or idea?

MK: In a nutshell, ENDYMA is a fashion archive that works at the intersection between rent and retail, functioning as both a resource and a shop. Over the years, I've really focused on Helmut Lang, of which ENDYMA now has the biggest collection in the world. I trace the details that make each object what it is and that made it come into fruition. So, to an extent, it's the result of my art history studies. Except instead of applying it to art, I chose to do it with clothes.

JM: Do you have an ideology that ENDYMA is rooted in?

MK: Yeah, I guess if I were to say that there's an ideology to this, it is my obsession, and kind of fetish, towards objects. My work always emphasizes the materiality of things, how they're constructed, how they behave in terms of construction or fabric. I focus on objects I find interesting and I'm not particularly interested in trends. What I'm trying to do with ENDYMA's detailed descriptions and photos is to accurately convey the materiality of garments. The ultimate aim is to achieve a sense of relevance that goes beyond short term statements.

JM: Is that something that you think more people are getting into - the idea that value is relevance beyond time-sensitivity?

MK: I think there's definitely a new generation of people who value this detail-centered approach. When one is facing an infinite quantity of clothes out there, distinctions between products become more nuanced. Helmut Lang did a very specific thing and in order to understand the significance of his work one inevitably has to inspect the garments closely. Lang's work is an exercise in detailing, for the most part. I feel like more people are aware of this now than ever before.

"I think we're living in a time where there's some serious uncertainty and I feel like that is largely reflected in fashion trends, in the sense that novelty is not really the priority. People are looking back to things that signify other time periods."



JM: Do you think the concept of archiving is becoming more important? Do you see that as a bigger cultural movement or trend?

MK: Yeah, absolutely. I think we're living in a time where there's some serious uncertainty and I feel like that is largely reflected in fashion trends, in the sense that novelty is not really the priority. People are looking back to things that signify other time periods. On one hand we have a culture of extremely discerning customers that really value their purchasing patterns and then we have people that are looking back to things that are seen as more authentic than what is happening now. I find the latter to be very tied with current political developments.

JM: We've seen so many examples of exclusive products, very time-sensitive products, very time-sensitive collaborations. What are your thoughts around the idea that everything's an exclusive now, everything's limited availability?

MK: Drop culture is pretty much the diametrical opposite to what I do. It's based on anxiety, speed and algorithmic bots purchasing stuff on your behalf so that you can flip them. I'm not interested to catching up with that approach because I'm slow. I really love what I do and I'm not just interested in cashing out - I'm interested in the people who are my customers, people who take a moment to look, discuss and make conscious choices. I think drop culture is primarily driven by the motivation of reselling and getting something quickly, which is a position that, to me, conveys insecurity.

"The concept of exclusivity has never been prized as much as it is now and I think people are refining their consumption more than ever before."



JM: Do you think people have lost perspective on how to judge an item because of the speed and anxiety cultivated by drop culture?

MK: I definitely think that peer pressure drives people to buy things that perhaps wouldn't normally be deemed worthy of attention. But at the same time, this is how humans create value, through associations with other things. So, there's nothing wrong about that, it's just a matter of who each of us wants to be and where we want to belong. Do we want to belong in this kind of spirit of our time or do we want to belong somewhere else?

JM: Do you think ideas around exclusivity with clothing are changing or do you think they've remained constant?

MK: The concept of exclusivity has never been prized as much as it is now and I think people are refining their consumption more than ever before. Beyond that, as far as my work is concerned, the product is inherently exclusive in the sense that it's very limited. That's certainly something that draws people to it - it's something that was designed many years ago but it's still very relevant now and no one else will have it.

JM: I think that's really interesting, the idea of individuals searching out their own piece of history. I'm also curious about knowledge-based exclusivity versus financially-driven exclusivity and if you've seen a growth in the knowledge-based exclusivity and people interested in the process of acquiring that knowledge?

MK: I think the kids that are growing up now, with an awareness of the concept of archival fashion, are people that know how to find things, know how to seek value outside of conventional channels. Therefore, what's valuable is not just what's on the window of Barney's. Money can help towards acquiring product, but it is ultimately knowledge that allows creators and consumers to harness a certain energy and keep the fire burning. For me, the knowledge aspect is what redeems my work. It's how I can go to bed at night.

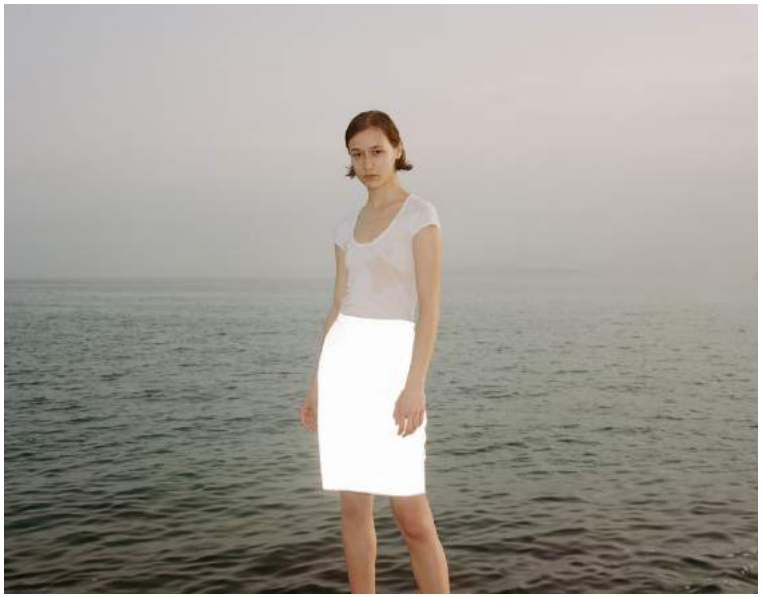
JM: I'm just thinking, what are the things that people are really interested in in terms of a narrative and in terms of process or provenance? What are the things they're yearning to learn?

MK: I think the people that come to the showroom in Athens, each of them has their own understanding of Helmut Lang or fashion in general. What I usually like to focus on is the way the garments were produced, the behind-the-scenes aspect. Information that is not instantly recognizable on a garment but is there.

JM: Amazing, okay, well I think that's all of my questions. Thank you so much for your time.

MK: It's a pleasure and I hope I wasn't way too ranty.

JM: No it's perfect, we love a good rant.



Photographer James Pearson-Howes & stylists Emily J Davies and Jake Hunte

PROSE

DATE: November 27, 2018

TIME: 1:30pm

We spoke to co-founder of Prose, Paul Michaux, about how his customizable hair care brand is changing beauty and forms of individuality.

Sophia Callahan: Hey, Paul. Could you briefly explain the concept of Prose?

Paul Michaux: Sure. We're a custom beauty company creating real hair care products based on holistic conversations with our customers. We start with a consultation that covers your hair and your scalp needs, but then goes deeper than that, into all aspects of your life that could have an impact on your hair and your scalp. In that context, Prose is one of a kind.

SC: That's why Prose is interesting - it takes into consideration the customer's ZIP code and the stress level they experience, and how that contributes to their hair quality. How do those wider lifestyle aspects play into the customization of someone's product?

PM: At some point, conventional brands began to make generalisations about their customers and those generalisations led to market segmentation; trying to put people into boxes, which in turn diverted people from their specific needs. We take a different approach. For example [at Prose], we don't believe that there is dry hair, per se. There are multiple reasons your hair might be dry: It could be because you use color or chemical products on your hair, or because you go swimming everyday, or because you're affected by pollution. It's about us being able to really understand why you have a specific need and then seeking the right ways for you to tackle the issue. If you look at the hair care market, and if you look at people's expectations, finding the right product is a real struggle. No one wants to compromise.



SC: You're able to communicate with your customer and to give them exactly what they need. Do you feel like you are building a community around your customer base?

PM: We're building one-on-one relationships with our customers. If you look at the brands on the market now, they're all trying to expand, so they come up with technology-based innovations. Whereas we start the conversation with our customer by listening to their needs and their desires. And then we formulate the product just for them. For us, it's about building a relationship where we want to make sure that you have your best hair days all the time. The feedback that you give us on our formula is our guide. And that helps us to improve the product for everyone.

SC: So it's like a feedback loop where the customer is constantly inputting, and you're constantly tweaking your algorithm?

"For us, it's about building a relationship where we want to make sure that you have your best hair days all the time. The feedback that you give to improve the product for everyone."

PM: It's exactly that, the whole idea is that. We're not working with pre-existing data, or trying to come up with ideas on a whim. We're building this conversation around your hair, your scalp, your needs and your lifestyle. We're asking the questions that we need answered in order to define those needs, and then using that data to come up with the best products to address them.

SC: Customization used to be something that was very expensive, but Prose is offering it at a very democratic price. What was the thought process behind allowing many people to experience something that's custom?

PM: I think we're challenging the perception of what luxury is in our world today. Luxury is no longer something that is only available at the highest price point. Customization is luxury itself, we could even call it the 'new luxury'. Of course it's not cheap. And the reason for that is because we have amazing ingredients in the formula. We have dynamic pricing in the sense that everyone should be paying for what they need, and what they get.

SC: Would you say that people are increasingly looking for value in the actual product rather than the branding around it?

PM: I think it's a combination of both. To be a strong brand today, we've got to have identity. When you're building your customer base and you're heavily relying on social media to bear acquisition, you need beautiful branding. While at the same time, you can't hide behind good marketing. If the quality of your product isn't there, consumers will know - and they will call you out for it.

SC: Do you think that customization is changing the concept of exclusivity?







> “ It’s a level of service: We’ll do everything possible to make sure that you have your best hair. As much as we can, we’re trying to make that service available to everyone. In that sense, maybe exclusivity isn’t excluding anyone anymore.”

PM: That’s an interesting question. I think customization plays into exclusivity. What we sell with Prose is the idea of being the first brand that came to you with a bespoke solution in a real and honest way. It’s a level of service: We’ll do everything possible to make sure that you have your best hair. As much as we can, we’re trying to make that service available to everyone. In that sense, maybe exclusivity isn’t excluding anyone anymore.

SC: I love that idea that exclusivity isn’t excluding anyone anymore. I think that’s a really nice place to come from, and it’s interesting because Prose is accessible and you do have all the options for everyone: Vegan, gluten free, silicone, but at the same time the end product is very specific. So, I think that’s a really interesting space you guys hold.

PM: There’s a good quote along the line of ‘inclusivity is the new exclusivity’.

SC: I like that, I mean those are all my questions. I appreciate you guys kind of speaking to me so much, this is super helpful.

PM: Thank you, have a good day.

SEXYLAND

DATE: November 26, 2018

TIME: 2pm

We spoke to Aukje Dekker, artist and co-founder of Sexyland, an Amsterdam based 'conceptual club' that gives members the opportunity to be a club owner for one night.



Aukje Dekker: Are you German?

Anna Lena Götzmann: Yeah, I'm German. Can you hear it?

AD: Yes. But you can hear I'm Dutch as well, so it's all good.

AG: Haha okay, cool. Do you have any questions for me upfront?

AD: No. I only think maybe I should sit down, I want to sit in our backstage, but it smells. I'll find a place, otherwise, I'll just walk. If it's not clear what I'm saying, then you just stop me, okay?

AG: Sure, make yourself comfortable. The zine we're creating is about exclusivity. So I'm curious, what are the first things that come to mind when you think about exclusivity?

AD: I think of a double-edged sword. On the one hand it means the opposite of open, so it's excluding. On the other, it means something special, which I like.

AG: How do you feel the concept of exclusivity has changed over the past years?

AD: I feel like it's becoming less popular.I think people generally like to feel special but they are a bit done with excluding clubs and memberships that only 'the cool people' have access to. It's like, these places are so pretentious and uninviting. Fuck that!

AG: Can you think of a place that makes people feel special without excluding them?

AD: Yeah, that's what we're trying to do at SEXYLAND. Our aim is to be extremely open and have no barrier for anyone who wants to be part of our society. But what makes people feel special is that beyond being a member you have the opportunity to be an owner for one night, which gives you a sense of pride. We want to make SEXYLAND a place where it's very easy to become an owner; you don't have to be rich or have a certain status. It's a very exclusive inclusive club.



Harris Hawk III - Lou-Lou van Staaveren

"I thought it would be pretty cool if you had a space where people are always happy, because every day it's operating at 100%. Within our concept, every day is a special day for the person that is owner."

AG: Beautiful! Can you tell me little bit about how you first got inspired to start SEXYLAND?

AD: For two reasons. First of all, I sometimes get annoyed that people can be really moody when they serve you. You go out for dinner, not only for the nice food, but also to be pampered a bit. Sometimes they forget that their job is not just to bring a beer, but to provide a service. I thought it would be pretty cool if you had a space where people are always happy, because every day we have a new owner, and it's their special day. So they come in with new energy and give it 100%. The other reason is that Sexyland was initiated by Eddie the Eagle Museum, an artist collective we started 9 years ago, preaching the art of failure. It's named after Eddie the Eagle, the worst ski jumper in the world who came last at the Olympics. To us, he's still a symbol of the art of trying.

AG: Haha, you should see me on a bike. Sounds super interesting, tell me more about Eddie the Eagle Museum.

AD: Well If you're really bad at something, and you just think, "Fuck it" like Eddie the Eagle thought "England doesn't have a ski jumper. I'm gonna be the one." Then you're our guy, he was just so terrible and overweight, and it was just brilliant. The word "Museum," is the juxtaposition we always look for; combining high end with trouble, famous musicians with street musicians, etc. but at one point we became more known and were asked for all this festivals and museums but never had our own space to give this a home. We decided we didn't want to be a sidekick of institutions to spice up their program anymore.

AG: So that's when you founded SEXYLAND?

AD: Yeah, with Sexyland, we created space for that, in which every owner is the main focus. No side programs here!



Kiki's House of Flying Daggers - Lou-Lou van Staaveren

"We always try to push further. If someone says "I want to cancel because I feel burned out," then we say, "Okay, then make it a meditation center." It has to be the mirror of the city of what everyone feels."

AG: Are there any criteria to get on board with SEXYLAND?

AD: There are. We never want to become a rental space but give a platform to people with strong visions that they want to bring to life. We wouldn't allow someone to just have a birthday party, there needs to be a concept: What do you feel Amsterdam is missing? What do you want to show? Other than that, there are almost no criteria.

AG: Okay, nice. I like the idea of making a change.

AD: Yeah, we always try to push further. If someone says "I want to cancel because I feel burned out," then we say, "Okay, then make it a meditation center." It has to be the mirror of the city of what everyone feels.

AG: What's the most surprising thing that you've come across since you started SEXYLAND?

AD: We have so many. It's very difficult, but one we just had very recently that was super surprising was a Chinese carrot cutting event. I absolutely loved it. There were carrots everywhere. I just didn't know people could make such beautiful things out of carrots.

AG: Oh my god, that sounds great!

AD: Also our Vogueing event was really cool, I had never seen a Kiki Ball before. The energy was amazing! Another party we had was a car park, where they drove old cars inside, and you could only play music from your car radio. That was also brilliant.

AG: Wow. This is great, I love all of this!

AG: One final question: How do you think exclusivity should be defined in the future?

AD: I think it's always nice to feel special, but I think the group for who something can be exclusive will be much broader. It won't just be for the obvious few.

AG: That's a nice note to end on. Thank you so much. It was so nice speaking to you.

LOT2046

DATE: November 27, 2018

TIME: 10am

Adam C. Passarella and Kyle Chayka are both subscribers to LOT2046. Here, they discuss the ideology, emotional connection and the exclusive community that the brand creates.

LOT CODE OF PRACTICES

Wear the uniform
Think long term (like 30 years from now)
Build stories and languages, not things
Create your own universe (or join ours)
Collect samples
Be a sample for somebody else
Look for loyalty, not for a skill set
Do not build utilitarian products. However, use them as a medium to express yourself
Do not exploit introverts — doesn't work long term. Learn to be an introvert yourself
Travel more
Do not work for corporations. Old corporations were meaningful when their founders were alive, but now, they have outlived their relevancy. They exist only to keep their numbers growing
New corporations are no better. They have scaled up features, and today's founders want hyper-growth for growth's sake (it seems like every line of code, every feature deserves its own corporation — it sure doesn't)
So, fuck the corporations
Tell the truth (bullshit never works long term)
Study and research fashion
Your phone is a temporary feature — don't spend your life on it (like you wouldn't spend it on a fax machine)
Fuck likes, followers, fake lives, fake friends
Remake your environment. Build it for yourself, and people will come
Only trust those who make things you love
Move to LA
Don't buy property
Don't go to Mars (just yet)
Use only one font, just a few colors, and just a few shapes
Use spreadsheets, but only to map out 30 cells — one for each year of the rest of your life
The next three are the most important
The past doesn't exist — don't get stuck in it
Don't go to Silicon Valley (it's not for you if you're still reading this)
Remind yourself daily: you and everyone you know will die
We must build the most beautiful things

We are 2046 kids

"I think the product was the ideology and the ideology was the product. The existence of the LOT product means that you have no choice and no free will. Or maybe that's the ultimate free will; I can't decide which."

Kyle Chayka: I think I first saw it online. They launched their homepage and it was just one long scroll of surreal images and monochrome clothes, shoes, a tattoo gun and all this stuff. I remember I couldn't tell if it was real or not. Like, is this just by a designer or is this an actual thing that I could buy? And then there was a checkout box on the site that said "Subscribe."

Adam C. Passarella: Yeah, I remember the first time seeing it, I thought it was like a uniform service for hipsters or something. What aspect really appealed to you overall?

KC: I think it was the paradox. This is not for everyone, you have to be kind of crazy to sign up for it. So you're automatically not like everyone else. Not everyone is radical enough for their service.

AC: Was it the tattoo gun?

KC: The tattoo gun definitely made it. That was the thing that took it beyond a fashion commodity to become this entire lifestyle.

AC: So it was more the product aspect versus the actual ideology?

KC: I think the product was the ideology and the ideology was the product. The existence of the LOT product means that you have no choice and no free will. Or maybe that's the ultimate free will; I can't decide which.

AC: Yeah, they kind of play off each other in a sense. How has your relationship with LOT developed since you've first started subscribing?

KC: When I first started subscribing, I was excited to get the T-shirts and the socks and stuff and then I really liked how it expanded from just the clothing into music playlists and a wider digital community.

AC: Like the Twitch TV?

KC: Yeah, the Twitch TV streams and just the dialogue of the members. LOT brought together this super specific group of people who are design/tech nerds and also weird, totalitarian philosophy people.



AC: When I first signed up, I remember sitting around and getting into a conversation about philosophy and hyperstition and super nerdy subjects, but at the same time joking about it... like what the hell is this thing?

KC: Fashion is obviously ideological, but this put it right at front and center, you know? LOT's clothing is not that different from other streetwear, but the idea is something that most streetwear brands wouldn't really address.

AC: Yeah, it's a little more evolved in a sense of consciousness. I remember one of the big things, too, was with the fit. The first time I got the shirts and the pants, the fits were definitely European.

KC: Totally. They do super skinny waist pants, but then the legs are super wide.

AC: Yeah, but I put in the notes back about it, and right after that, they kind of nailed the fit.

KC: Yeah, the customization, the idea of like an AI clothing service that gradually adjusted to what you want was cool to me. I still feel like it should adjust more, honestly.

AC: Yeah, I get that. Do you think there's a community around the people that are subscribed? I feel like you're a die-hard and there are different types of LOT subscribers; super hardcore versus the laid-back.

KC: Well, you can choose how much you participate, right? It's like any fashion brand. Some people are super obsessed with Gucci, and all their shit is Gucci, or they just have one bag or something. With LOT, it's supposed to be your whole life, but it doesn't have to be, you know?

AC: It doesn't have to consume you.

KC: Right. But I wish it would. Maybe it's impossible to have a clothing brand that is equally applicable to everyone.

AC: I mean, in a sense it's really like taking the whole lifestyle aspect of brand and taking it almost to the next level.



"Subscribing means that you're looking for a different lifestyle and you would like an alternative to what exists out there right now. It is a way of saying, "I'm not interested in giant luxury fashion brands. I'm not interested in the usual symbols of success or taste.""

KC: It expands into every facet of your life. Which is what all clothing brands would like to do theoretically, right?

AC: Yeah. It's a bit more overt, I guess. Is being a member of LOT a form of protest or criticism to the current state?

KC: I think it is. Subscribing means that you're looking for a different lifestyle and you would like an alternative to what exists out there right now. It is a way of saying, "I'm not interested in giant luxury fashion brands. I'm not interested in the usual symbols of success or taste." I understand there's this more subtle, abstract, intense thing, which is the LOT lifestyle.

AC: That makes a lot of sense. How do you think LOT changes your concepts of individuality?

KC: I think it deconstructs your sense of self a bit. Subscribing to LOT or wearing it means that instead of expressing your individuality you're expressing this belonging to a larger, more abstract group of LOT subscribers. It's a funny paradox because wearing them, you're like, "no one can tell what brand I'm wearing" or "it doesn't really say anything about me," but to other LOT subscribers, you can identify them, and you feel like you're a part of this tribe.

AC: The shoes.

KC: The shoes, yeah. My friend texted me one day saying, "I saw someone carrying a LOT backpack, and I wanted to go up and say hi to them, but I didn't."

AC: I forget where I was, but I had on a LOT T-shirt, LOT shoes this past summer and next thing I know, I checked Instagram, and someone had spotted me and they posted it like "Wearing LOT!" And I was like "What the hell?" It was the randomest thing ever, but they knew someone I knew and it was just this whole LOT insider thing that was kind of funny, actually.

KC: I think that's the thing about it, it actually brings together a group of people who probably are within one degree of separation from each other anyway.

AC: Exactly.

KC: It's a group connected by the Internet and social networks and music and books. LOT is the first clothing brand to address that specific group or address that idea.

AC: How do you think LOT is creating new forms of exclusivity?

KC: I think the LOT form of exclusivity is belonging.

AC: "Belonging."

KC: The community is exclusive, and it's not necessarily exclusive in a monetary or economic way, the way luxury fashion is, but it's exclusive in a commitment way. You have to be committed a little bit to this idea of no more brands, no visible logos.

AC: It's a bit like hardcore punk.

KC: Yeah, because it's rebelling against the usual status structure and you have to be willing to do that. The barrier is being willing to do that, totally like punk. Like being willing to wear the ripped-up T-shirt and chains and alienate people. I think the LOT clothes are alienating, they alienate other people, or they kind of alienate the self.

AC: It reminds me of those Instagram memes where you see the starter pack.

KC: Yeah, LOT is like the starter pack of nihilism. It's like accepting that all identities are meaningless collections of things, anyway, so you might as well have this collection of things.

AC: Yeah, and in a deeper sense, it's almost like the loss of self, honestly, by blending in.

KC: The willingness to blend in is a form of exclusivity, I think.

AC: I definitely agree. Do you think that drop culture has affected the value placed on clothing?

KC: Drop culture turns clothing into something that's more like a movie, a video game or a TV show. It's this continuous feed of novelty and new stuff. And it's always short-term exclusivity, so a Supreme thing will drop, and it'll be super valuable for a week, and then the value of it will literally fall.

AC: Yeah, I know, it's almost like a direct representation of what I think a lot of people are getting burned out on.

KC: In an emotional way, drops become a part of your everyday life. You get addicted to the new stuff. You want the newest, latest thing, because that's what'll bring you the most cache among your community.

AC: Do you thinks LOT is responding to drop culture in a different way?

KC: I think LOT comes out of drop culture. Because you get a new thing every month and it's constantly evolving. But it's also deconstructing drop culture, because you get the same stuff over and over. It's not promising the newest and latest, instead it's promising that it really gets better over time. It's improving a product; it's evolving versus just having more novelty.

AC: I remember my conversation that I had with Vadik last week, and we were talking about this, and he was saying, though, the attention to detail is just like having a brand that cares.

KC: Right, some of the streetwear brands seem like they hate their buyer.

AC: Yeah, it's really different to have a brand that actually seems like they care about how you're feeling or whatever.

KC: I feel like it's creating a new model for a relationship between brands and consumers.

AC: Yeah, like a new way of doing business.

"The community is exclusive, and it's not necessarily exclusive in a monetary or economic way, the way luxury fashion is, but it's exclusive in a commitment way. You have to be committed a little bit to this idea of no more brands, no visible logos."

KC: We subscribe to Netflix or Amazon or Hulu or whatever, why wouldn't we subscribe to a clothing brand?

AC: So what do you think about the idea of knowledge-based exclusivity versus financial based exclusivity?

KC: I think one translates into the other. I think maybe knowledge-based exclusivity is more valuable because it's harder to establish.

AC: Very true. I think that's pretty much it, is there anything else you want to add?

KC: I think LOT has so much potential, and it's just the start of something.



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